



LEO XIV visits Sicily's Gateway of Europe monument Saturday in tribute to the hardships faced by migrants.

Pontiff asserts authority on world matters

Leo XIV takes some by surprise with a run of decisions in which he sets the agenda.

By NICOLE WINFIELD

ROME — Pope Leo XIV began a summer break on Sunday, capping a whirlwind finale to the first half of 2026 in which he emerged as a powerful global statesman on issues including artificial intelligence and war and flexed decisive papal muscle to govern internal church problems.

Leo acknowledged in the summer of 2025, after the church's cardinals elected him pope, that he had a big learning curve on being a head of state. The last few weeks have shown his governing style and a remarkable run of papal decision-making where Leo has set the agenda, rather than merely fulfill the appointments set by his predecessor.

"Many people last year would have predicted a quiet papacy on the world stage and a focus on internal reform and governance," said Austen Ivereigh, who is the biographer of Pope Francis. "But the first half of 2026 has shown the opposite: Ironically, the one area where Leo had least confidence, as international statesman, is where his pontificate has really taken off."

[See Pope, A3]

Memorial for 3 firefighters

Helicopter-based crew members were killed battling a blaze along the Colorado-Utah border. **NATION, A7**

Federal climate data restored

Axed government employees fight back against the dismantling of a key website. **CALIFORNIA, B3**

Groundbreaking politician dies

Billy G. Mills was one of the first Black men to serve on the L.A. City Council. He was 96. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

Weather

Partly sunny. L.A. Basin: 84/63. **B5**

For the latest news, go to **latimes.com**.



Federal loan caps force a rethink of grad school

By ANDREW KHOURI

New federal rules sharply cap how much graduate students can borrow, forcing an immediate sea change in how students evaluate attaining an advanced degree, with some scrambling to pay tuition — and for colleges, prompting concerns about future access to their programs.

Under the previous rules, graduate students could take out federal loans for as much as they needed to cover the cost of their master's and doctorate degrees, in-

cluding tuition and living expenses, often taking on crushing, long-term debt that contributed to a national epidemic in defaults.

Effective July 1, borrowing is restricted to \$20,500 annually, with a \$100,000 cap. Those pursuing designated professional degrees, including law, medicine and dentistry, are limited to \$50,000 a year with a \$200,000 cap.

The median total cost for a master's degree in 2020 — before inflation skyrocketed — was \$24,250, while professional degrees came in at \$59,076, though some uni-

versities — particularly private institutions — charge far more, according to EdTrust, a nonprofit that advocates for equity in education.

The Trump administration clamped down on borrowing — part of its overhaul in the federal student loan programs — saying that the previous uncapped loans for graduate school spiraled tuition upward and that the limits will encourage colleges to trim costs.

Already, at least two graduate school programs in California, including the [See Loans, A5]



GIANNA Lopez and classmates do math at Laurel Elementary in Compton.

Math tests in kindergarten? California may require them

By CIERRA MORGAN

Confronted with math test scores showing that 68% of California public school third-graders do not meet grade-level standards, state lawmakers are considering one way to potentially reverse the trend: Give kindergartners a math test to find out if they are ready for the rigors of first grade.

Do they have a sense of what numbers mean? Can they group items? Can they

compare quantities? Do they know the difference between a square and a circle?

By discovering what the state's youngest students know about early, foundational math concepts, teachers can better target weaknesses before their skills sink, said supporters of the early tests.

Senate Bill 1067, authored by state Sen. Akilah Weber Pierson (D-La Mesa), will require every public school to assess students in kindergarten through second grade for early math difficulties and pro-

[See Math, A8]

FIFA rescinds Balogun's suspension after red card

By KEVIN BAXTER

SEATTLE — FIFA made a discipline change for just the second time in its history, clearing the way for U.S. striker Folarin Balogun to play in Monday's elimination game with Belgium at the World Cup.

The rare move drew celebration from the U.S. players who felt Balogun's red card was unjust and drew outrage from the Belgium team and others protective of the integrity of the laws of soccer.

FIFA, the global governing body for soccer and the organizer of the World Cup,

announced Sunday morning that the one-game suspension given to Balogun for a dangerous challenge that could have injured an opponent in last week's win over Bosnia-Herzegovina would be held in abeyance, making him eligible to play in what is arguably the team's most important game in at least a generation.

It was the first time FIFA has rescinded a red-card suspension during a World Cup in 64 years.

The Belgium team immediately protested the decision, with the country's soccer federation saying it was "astonished" by the rul-

ing and was "investigating all potential options" to block it and "safeguard the legitimate rights of all participating teams and to protect the fundamental principles of fair in our sport."

It was unclear what those options might be.

"I didn't know the game was being played on April Fool's Day rather than July 6," Belgian coach Rudi Garcia said. "We're not defending the national team or federation. We are defending football."

President Trump celebrated the reversal on his social media platform. [See FIFA, A8]

14 propositions could reshape taxes, housing, care and voting

California residents will have to decide on these measures on the November ballot.

By IRIS KWOK AND NICOLE NIXON

California voters will decide 14 statewide propositions in the Nov. 3 election, measures placed on the ballot mostly by either powerful interest groups or lawmakers that will affect the lives of millions of Californians.

While a proposed tax on state billionaires has dominated headlines, voters will also have a chance to weigh in on a number of consequential issues — health-care, voter identification requirements and more.

Californians are accustomed to legislating by the ballot and often face a list of propositions. But even by the standards of the state's direct democracy process, the 2026 election stands out. The campaigns supporting and opposing the ballot measures have already collected more than \$100 million in contributions, and are expected to use their money to inundate the television airwaves, livestreams and social media feeds and

to flood mailboxes with glossy campaign mailers over the coming months.

Here are the measures on the Nov. 3 ballot:



Proposition 1: Veterans and Affordable Housing Bond Act of 2026

Spurred by the state's affordable housing shortage, state lawmakers are asking voters to approve an \$11.25-billion bond to boost affordable housing construction around the state.

Advocates say the funds would help build more than 40,000 shovel-ready affordable homes that are unable to move forward because of a financing gap and help preserve thousands of other existing units.

Proposition 1 includes specific funding for high-needed groups, including \$1.25 billion for a veterans' home loan program, \$1.15 billion for supportive housing for homeless people, \$350 million for student housing at [See Propositions, A6]

Scientists warn of 'uncharted' heat

El Niño and already warmer oceans may put U.S. in dangerous temperature territory.

By RONG-GONG LIN II

As extreme heat smothered the eastern United States over the July Fourth weekend and Europe struggled with its own deadly heat wave, experts warned that more record high temperatures could be in store for this year because of a strengthening El Niño.

"We know that temperatures are warming in the long term, linked to human-caused climate change, and El Niño acts to boost those temperatures temporarily," climate scientist Zachary Labe of the nonprofit Climate Central said in a recent briefing.

Between June 2025 and April, Labe said, global average surface temperatures were about 1.8 to 2.7 degrees above pre-Industrial Revolution levels. But an average of forecast models suggests global average surface temperatures could be even higher in the winter — perhaps hitting 3.24 to 3.42 degrees above the pre-Industrial Revolution era.

"This would indicate a very high likelihood that we

will be breaking new global temperature records in just a few months," Labe said.

Although California escaped oppressive heat conditions over the weekend, officials issued a heat advisory for Tuesday through Thursday, when temperatures could hit 90 to 103 degrees across inland areas of Los Angeles, Ventura, Santa Barbara and San Luis Obispo counties.

Beyond California, scientists are raising alarms over the planet's warming oceans, which — coupled with a strong El Niño — could increase temperatures for land dwellers in the coming weeks.

On Wednesday, officials confirmed that the global sea surface temperature in June hit a record for this time of year.

"Current conditions could indicate the beginning of a new phase, leading, once more, to uncharted territory. With ocean temperatures at these levels and El Niño on the horizon, we are likely to see more temperature records fall in the coming months," said Carlo Buontempo, director of the Copernicus Climate Change Service, an arm of the European Union.

Warming ocean waters have wide-ranging effects, scientists say. They can pro-

[See Heat, A7]



ROBERT GAUTHIER Los Angeles Times

FOLARIN BALOGUN, right, celebrates with U.S. teammate Weston McKennie after scoring June 12.